

The Pentagon

*The world's largest office building
and an embodiment of US military power*



Few visitors to the Pentagon—located just across the Potomac River in Virginia from Washington, D.C.—describe it as a beautiful building. However, as the headquarters of the US Department of Defense, it serves an important purpose, housing around 25,000 military and civilian staff. The building was designed by American architect George Bergstrom and completed on January 15, 1943.

Prime target

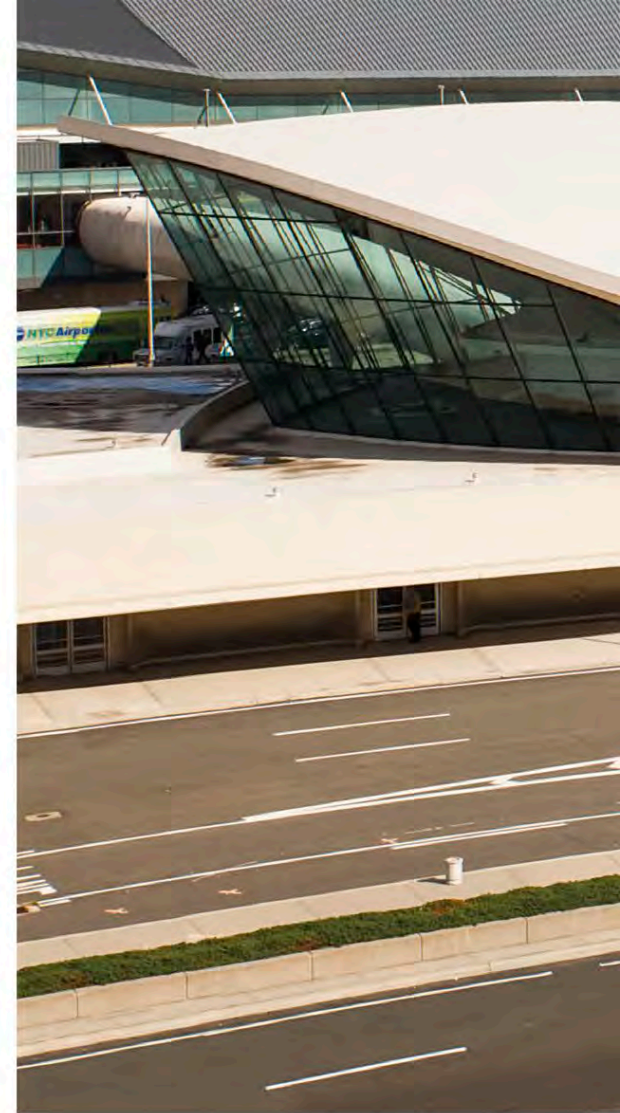
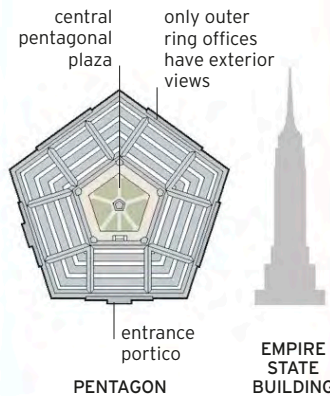
The Pentagon has five even-length sides, with five floors above ground and two below it, providing more than 6,500,000 square ft (600,000 square m) of space and 17 miles (28km) of corridors. At its center is a 215,000-square-ft (20,000-square-m) pentagonal plaza nicknamed “ground zero,” on the presumption that if the Soviet Union had attacked the US in a nuclear conflict during the Cold War, the Pentagon would have been the prime target. Although it survived the Cold War intact, the Pentagon was attacked on 9/11, when hijackers flew American Airlines Flight 77 into the western side of the building, killing 189 people, including 125 Pentagon employees.

▽ CAREFULLY PLANNED

Constructed of steel and reinforced concrete with some limestone facing, the Pentagon has five floors. It comprises five concentric rings that are connected by 10 spokelike corridors.

GIANT SCALE

The Pentagon is vast in scale, covering an area of 172,000 square ft (16,000 square m), including the central plaza. Each of its five sides is 918 ft (280 m) long, and the building is almost as wide as the Empire State building in New York is tall. The Pentagon's distinctive shape was determined by the need for it to fit between existing roads at the site, and its height was limited by the relative scarcity of steel at the time of its construction.



△ STREAMLINED DESIGN

A symbol of rapid transformation in its time, the terminal's roof was deliberately designed to look like the wings of an aircraft. This also provided TWA with a new way of marketing its services. The roof's thin, reinforced concrete shell is lightly supported at its corners.



It is possible for a person to **walk** between any **two rooms** in the Pentagon in less than **7 minutes**

A NEW PURPOSE

After the closure of the TWA Flight Center in 2001, the building remained vacant but was used occasionally as a venue for art exhibitions and as a movie set. In 2008, a new terminal building capable of handling far higher volumes of passengers was built next to the old building, which was subsequently repurposed as a hotel.

